

CONTENT STRATEGY LAB

HarborTrail Client Sprint Simulation

A no-cost, experiential content marketing simulation

Course: Content Creation for Social Media

Instructor: Dr. Emre Ulusoy

Student Simulation Packet and Response Template

Student Name	Douglass Brown
Canvas Due Date	See Canvas
Submission Format	Completed Word document or exported PDF
Public Posting Required?	No

How to use this document

Download this file, type directly into the response areas, save your completed version, and submit it to Canvas. You may also export it as a PDF before submitting. Complete all five rounds in order because later rounds build on earlier campaign results.

Document Roadmap

Section	What you will find
1. Assignment Overview	Purpose, learning goals, submission expectations, and grading overview
2. Client Brief	HarborTrail background, products, brand voice, campaign goals, personas, search intent, channels, and budget menu
3. Simulation Rounds	Five applied rounds with client memos, analytics, budgets, tasks, and response templates
4. Final Requirements	AI use disclosure, citation expectations, accessibility expectations, final checklist, and rubric

1. Assignment Overview

In this assignment, you will act as a content marketing manager for HarborTrail Outfitters, a fictional outdoor and travel lifestyle brand. Your job is to make strategic content decisions, create content, interpret performance data, revise your approach, and write a final recommendation based on the results of a simulated campaign.

This assignment is a no-cost, document-based alternative to a paid content marketing simulation. It is designed to feel practical and experiential even though it is completed through a Word/PDF portfolio. You are not simply writing about content marketing. You are practicing the work of a content strategist.

Learning Objectives

- Analyze target audience personas and connect audience needs to content choices.
- Plan content based on target market, search intent, brand voice, and platform fit.
- Create blog, short-form video, podcast/audio, email, and campaign content concepts.
- Use SEO keyword logic and search intent to support content planning.
- Allocate a limited fictional content budget across content activities.
- Interpret mock analytics and use performance data to adjust content strategy.
- Evaluate your own content decisions through a client quality check.
- Write a professional final strategy memo that connects creative choices to business goals.

At a Glance

Your role	Content marketing manager for HarborTrail Outfitters
Number of rounds	Five applied simulation rounds
Estimated time	Approximately 60 to 90 minutes per round
Public posting	Not required
Video/audio recording	Optional. A detailed script, storyboard, or production plan is acceptable.
Peer review	Not required in this version. You will complete a Client Quality Check instead.
Submission	One completed Word document or PDF uploaded to Canvas
Grading	100-point rubric converted to the Canvas point value

Important note

You are not required to post anything publicly, show your face, record your voice, reveal personal information, or use copyrighted media. This is a strategy and content creation simulation, not a public performance requirement.

2. Client Brief

Client Background

HarborTrail Outfitters is a small outdoor and travel lifestyle brand based in the Pacific Northwest. The company sells practical, affordable gear for everyday adventures, short trips, campus life, commuting, day hikes, family outings, and weekend travel.

HarborTrail is not trying to be an elite outdoor brand only for expert hikers. Its brand personality is friendly, inclusive, practical, and community-oriented. The brand wants people to feel that adventure can be simple, affordable, accessible, and part of everyday life.

HarborTrail Products

Product	Price	Description
Everyday Daypack	\$48	Lightweight backpack for school, commuting, and short trips
Commuter Backpack	\$72	Larger backpack with laptop sleeve and rain-resistant material
Insulated Water Bottle	\$24	Reusable bottle for campus, work, hiking, and travel
Travel Organizer Set	\$29	Small packing cubes and cable/accessory organizers
Weekend Tote	\$64	Durable tote for short trips, gym, errands, and travel
Compact Picnic Mat	\$36	Foldable mat for parks, beaches, and outdoor events
Trail Comfort Kit	\$32	Small kit with reusable utensils, napkin, sunscreen pouch, and mini first-aid basics

Brand Voice

- Friendly and clear
- Practical and encouraging
- Inclusive and not intimidating
- Slightly playful when appropriate
- Focused on everyday adventure, not extreme outdoor performance
- Never too corporate, too luxury-focused, or too survivalist

Campaign Goals

1. Increase brand awareness.
2. Grow social media engagement.
3. Increase website visits.
4. Improve email signups.
5. Encourage product clicks and purchases.
6. Build community around accessible local adventure.
7. Learn which audiences and content types perform best.

Target Audience Personas

Persona	Profile	Platforms	Content Preferences	Possible Keywords
Campus Explorer Alex	College student with limited time and budget. Wants useful gear for school, studying, commuting, and occasional weekend trips.	TikTok, Instagram Reels, YouTube Shorts, Reddit	Short videos, quick tips, student hacks, 'what's in my bag,' relatable humor, budget-friendly recommendations	affordable backpack for students; campus backpack essentials; college daypack; study day bag; weekend trip on a budget
Weekend Planner Maya	Young professional who wants easy weekend escapes, short hikes, local coffee shops, road trips, parks, beaches, and simple travel planning.	Instagram, Pinterest, TikTok, blogs, Google Search	Weekend guides, packing lists, beautiful visuals, itineraries, short-form video, '3 places to go this weekend' content	weekend trip packing list; day trip essentials; easy weekend adventure; what to pack for a day hike; local travel gear
Family Outing Nora	Parent or caregiver who plans simple family outings and wants safe, organized, low-stress ideas for parks, picnics, and short trips.	Facebook, Google Search, email newsletters, Instagram	Checklists, family outing guides, planning tips, product bundles, email reminders, practical blog posts	family picnic checklist; what to pack for a family day trip; park day essentials; family outing packing list
Low-Waste Traveler Riley	Sustainability-minded consumer who wants reusable products, mindful consumption, and transparent brand communication.	Instagram, blogs, YouTube, email newsletters, Pinterest	Educational posts, product transparency, low-waste tips, behind-the-scenes content, comparison guides	reusable travel essentials; low waste day trip; sustainable packing list; eco friendly travel gear; reduce waste while traveling

Search Intent Options

Intent	What it means	Examples	Best content types
Informational	The audience wants to learn something.	How to pack for a day trip; what should I bring to campus?	Guides, tutorials, checklists, educational videos
Commercial Investigation	The audience is comparing options before deciding.	Best backpack for college students; backpack vs. tote for weekend travel	Comparison posts, product guides, review-style content, buying guides
Transactional	The audience is close to taking action or making a purchase.	Buy commuter backpack; affordable daypack under \$50	Product pages, promotional emails, product-focused posts, clear CTAs
Community/Engagement	The audience wants connection, inspiration, or participation.	Weekend challenge; show us what's in your bag	Social campaigns, polls, challenges, user-generated content prompts

Budget Menu

Each round gives you a fictional budget. You are not spending real money. The budget is a strategic constraint. You must choose activities from the menu and stay within the round budget.

Content Activity	Cost	Best Used For
Organic social post	\$0	Simple engagement, announcements, quick content
Instagram carousel	\$75	Tips, checklists, educational content
Blog post, standard	\$150	SEO, education, search traffic
Blog post, short	\$100	Quick guide or announcement
Short-form vertical video	\$150	Awareness, engagement, product demos
Polished short-form video	\$250	Higher-quality campaign content
Podcast or audio/video podcast segment	\$150	Trust, storytelling, deeper engagement

Content Activity	Cost	Best Used For
Email newsletter	\$75	Email growth, conversion, repeat engagement
Paid social media boost	\$100	Increasing reach for a strong post
Basic photo package	\$100	Product visuals, lifestyle images
Local creator collaboration	\$250	Awareness, credibility, community reach
Downloadable checklist or guide	\$200	Email signups, lead generation
SEO keyword research support	\$50	Improving search strategy

Channel Options

TikTok, Instagram Reels, Instagram carousel/post, YouTube Shorts, blog/website, email newsletter, Facebook, Pinterest, Reddit/community forum, local event calendar, and creator/influencer collaboration.

Required Portfolio Format

Submit one completed portfolio document on Canvas. Use this file as your template and type directly into the response areas. Your final submission should include all five rounds, the final reflection, AI use disclosure, and references if applicable.

- Round 1: Blog/Search Content Request
- Round 2: Short-Form Video Strategy
- Round 3: Podcast/Audio and Email Strategy
- Round 4: Analytics and Budget Reallocation
- Round 5: Final Integrated Strategy Memo
- Final Reflection
- AI Use Disclosure
- References, if applicable

3. Simulation Rounds

Before you begin

Complete the rounds in order. Each round builds on earlier results. Use the fictional data provided in this document as if it came from HarborTrail's campaign dashboard.

Round 1: Blog/Search Content Request

Client Memo

HarborTrail is not yet well known. The owner wants to attract people who are searching online for practical advice related to everyday travel, campus life, commuting, short trips, family outings, or local adventures. Your task is to plan and create a blog post that helps the right audience discover HarborTrail.

Round budget	\$300
Main focus	Search-driven blog content
Required artifact	500 to 700 word blog post draft

Required Tasks

1. Choose one primary target persona.
2. Choose one primary campaign goal.
3. Choose one search intent.
4. Choose one SEO keyword phrase.
5. Choose your content activities from the budget menu and stay within \$300.
6. Write a content request.
7. Create a blog post draft of approximately 500 to 700 words.
8. Explain why your choices fit together strategically.
9. Complete the Client Quality Check.

Suggested Blog Topics

- What to Pack for a Low-Stress Day Trip
- The College Student's Guide to a Better Everyday Backpack
- How to Plan a Simple Weekend Adventure Without Overpacking
- Family Outing Essentials: A Practical Packing Checklist
- Low-Waste Travel Basics for Everyday Adventures

Round 1 Response Template

Target Persona	Weekend Planner Maya
Primary Goal	Increase website visits and product clicks
Search Intent	Informational with Commercial investigation potential
SEO Keyword Phrase	Weekend Trip packing list

Content Type	Standard blog post supported by SEO keyword research
Distribution Channel(s)	HarborTrail blog post/website, Pinterest pin, Instagram Story, email newsletter mention
Budget Allocation	Blog post, standard: \$150; SEO Keyword research support: \$50, Instagram carousel repurpose: \$75. Total \$275 of \$300.
Proposed Title	How to Plan a Simple Weekend Adventure Without Overpacking
Main Message	A good weekend adventure does not require expensive gear or strategic planning. A simple and practical packing system makes local travel easier.
Call to Action	Download HarborTrail's free weekend packing checklist and check out our Travel Organizer Set and Everyday Daypack.
Success Metric	Blog views, average time on page, checklist downloads, product clicks and email signups.

Content Request: Explain the target persona, goal, search intent, keyword, content type, distribution channel, title, main message, CTA, budget, and success metric.

Weekend Planner Maya is a young professional who wants simple weekend escapes, day trips, parks, coffee stops, beaches, and short hikes without overpacking. The primary goal is to increase website visits and product clicks by capturing informational search traffic for the keyword phrase “weekend trip packing list.” The post should use a friendly, clear, practical HarborTrail voice and avoid sounding elite, expensive, or survivalist. The content will live on the HarborTrail blog and be distributed through Pinterest, Instagram Stories, and a short email mention. Budget will prioritize a standard blog post, light SEO keyword support, and one repurposed Instagram carousel. The post title is “How to Plan a Simple Weekend Adventure Without Overpacking.” The main CTA will invite readers to download a free weekend packing checklist and explore practical HarborTrail items such as the Travel Organizer Set, Everyday Daypack, Insulated Water Bottle, and Compact Picnic Mat. Success will be measured through blog views, time on page, checklist downloads, product clicks, and email signups.

Blog Post Draft: Write approximately 500 to 700 words. Include a clear title, short introduction, at least three useful sections or tips, the keyword used naturally, and a call to action.

How to Plan a Simple Weekend Adventure Without Overpacking

A weekend adventure should feel refreshing, not like preparing for a month-long expedition. Whether you are heading to a nearby beach, a local trail, a coffee shop in another town, or a quick overnight visit, the right packing system can help you feel ready without carrying half your closet. This weekend trip packing list is built for real life: simple plans, limited space, and affordable everyday gear.

Start with the plan, not the bag.

Before you pack anything, decide what kind of day you are actually planning. A park picnic, short hike, campus study picnic, and overnight road trip all need different items. Write down three basics: where you are going, how long you will be gone, and what weather or activities you expect. This keeps your bag focused. If your plan is only a few hours, you probably do not need extra shoes, three outfits, or a full toiletry kit. You need the things that remove friction: water, layers, snacks, phone charger, sun protection, and a simple place to sit.

Use a three-zone packing system.

Instead of tossing everything into one bag, divide your packing into three zones: essentials, comfort, and activity items. Essentials include wallet, keys, phone, charger, water bottle, and any medication. Comfort items include a light jacket, sunscreen, sunglasses, hand wipes, and a small first-aid pouch. Activity items depend on the plan, such as a book, camera, journal, picnic mat, reusable utensils, or headphones. A small organizer set helps keep these categories separate, so you do not have to dig through your bag every time you need one cable or sunscreen pouch.

Choose one flexible bag.

A weekend trip does not always require luggage. For most short adventures, one useful daypack or tote can cover the full plan. A lightweight backpack works well for walking, hiking, campus, or public transportation. A durable tote works better for park days, gym stops, errands, or beach afternoons. The goal is not to carry more. The goal is to carry smarter. HarborTrail's Everyday Daypack is a strong option for people who want one bag for school, work, and spontaneous trips. The Weekend Tote fits people who prefer open space and quick access.

Pack reusable items first.

Simple reusable gear can save money and reduce waste. Bring an insulated water bottle instead of buying plastic bottles throughout the day. Add reusable utensils and a napkin if food is part of the plan. A compact picnic mat can turn a park, beach, or overlook into a comfortable stop. These items are small, but they make the trip feel more intentional.

Leave space for the unexpected.

One of the easiest packing mistakes is filling your bag completely before the day even begins. Leave room for a hoodie, a snack you buy on the road, a small souvenir, or something you pick up from a local shop. A half-full bag is often more useful than a perfectly packed but overloaded one.

The best weekend adventures are not about having the most gear. They are about feeling prepared enough to say yes to a simple plan. Download HarborTrail's free weekend packing checklist, then explore the Everyday Daypack, Travel Organizer Set, Insulated Water Bottle, and Compact Picnic Mat to build your own easy adventure setup.

Strategy Explanation: In 150 to 250 words, explain why your persona, keyword, content type, channel, and CTA fit together strategically.

Weekend Planner Maya is the best fit for search-driven blog content because her planning behavior includes Google Search, blogs, Pinterest, and visually useful guides. The keyword phrase "weekend trip packing list" matches informational intent because Maya is likely trying to solve a practical planning problem before she is ready to buy. However, the topic also creates a natural bridge to commercial investigation because

readers may begin comparing bags, organizers, water bottles, and comfort items. A blog post is appropriate because it can capture search traffic over time, while the Instagram carousel and Pinterest distribution make the same advice more visual and shareable. The CTA is clear but not too aggressive: first download the checklist, then explore relevant products. That sequence supports HarborTrail's inclusive brand voice by helping first and selling second. The budget also fits the round because it reserves money for SEO support and a visual repurpose rather than spending everything on one isolated post.

Client Quality Check: 1) How does your content fit the audience? 2) How does it support the goal? 3) Why is the channel appropriate? 4) Is the CTA clear? 5) What would you improve with more time?

The content fits Weekend Planner Maya because it gives practical weekend planning advice without assuming expert outdoor knowledge or expensive gear. It supports the goal by bringing people to the website through search and then encouraging checklist downloads and product clicks. The blog is appropriate because Maya uses Google Search and blogs when planning trips; Pinterest and Instagram extend the same idea into visual discovery. The CTA is clear because readers know exactly what to do next: download the checklist and explore relevant products. With more time, I would add original lifestyle photos and test two different headlines to see which earns more clicks from search and social previews.

Round 2: Short-Form Video Strategy

Client Memo

HarborTrail's first blog content produced some search traffic, but social media performance needs improvement. The owner wants a short-form video that feels useful, natural, and platform-appropriate.

Round 1 Mock Analytics

Metric	Result
Total blog views	520
Unique views	440
Average time on page	1 minute, 08 seconds
Product clicks	31
Email signups	12
Social shares	9
Blog conversion rate	2.3%
Strongest traffic source	Google Search
Weakest traffic source	Social media

Round budget	\$400
Main focus	Short-form video strategy
Required artifact	30 to 60 second video script, storyboard, production plan, or optional video link

Required Tasks

1. Interpret the Round 1 analytics.
2. Choose one primary target persona.
3. Choose one primary goal for the video.
4. Choose one platform for the video.
5. Choose your content activities from the budget menu and stay within \$400.
6. Create a short-form video plan.
7. Write a script or storyboard. Recording the video is optional.
8. Write a caption and call to action.
9. Complete the Client Quality Check.

Video Ideas

- What's in my bag for a long campus day
- Three things to pack for a spontaneous weekend trip
- Day trip packing mistakes to avoid
- One backpack, three uses: school, work, weekend
- Low-waste travel swap: disposable bottle vs. reusable bottle

Round 2 Response Template

Analytics Interpretation: In 100 to 150 words, explain what the Round 1 results suggest. What seems to be working? What needs improvement?

Search content is working better than social distribution. The blog reached 520 total views and 440 unique views, and Google Search was the strongest traffic source. Topic and keyword logic helped people discover HarborTrail when they were already looking for practical advice. Product clicks and email signups show some movement toward conversion, but social shares were low and social media was the weakest traffic source. The next move should translate the useful blog idea into faster, more visual content. A short-form video can turn the packing-list concept into a quick, relatable demonstration that builds engagement and drives viewers back to the checklist or product page.

Target Persona	Campus Explorer Alex
Primary Goal	Grow social media engagement and increase product clicks
Platform	TikTok
Video Hook	"Stop carrying three bags for one long campus day."
Main Message	A simple bag setup can handle class, commuting, studying, food and a quick evening plan.
Visual Plan or Shot List	Fast cuts: overloaded bag, reset on table, three packing zones, final bag check, CTA, screen.
Caption	One bag. Long day. Less chaos. Here is a practical campus pack setup that actually works.
Call to Action	Save this packing setup and tap the link for the free Campus Bag Checklist
Budget Allocation	Short-form vertical video: \$150; basic photo package: \$100; paid social media boost: \$100. Total \$350 of \$400.

Success Metric

Views, engagement rate, saves, shares, link clicks, and checklist downloads.

Video Script, Storyboard, or Production Plan: Write enough detail that someone else could produce the video from your instructions. You may also include a video link if you choose to record it.

Format: 30 to 45 second vertical TikTok video.

0:00-0:03 - Hook shot: A student drops an overstuffed backpack and loose tote on a desk. On-screen text: “Stop carrying three bags for one campus day.” Voiceover: “If your campus bag feels like a survival mission, reset it like this.”

0:04-0:10 - Table layout: Empty the bag and arrange items into three piles. On-screen text: “Zone 1: Essentials.” Show laptop, notebook, wallet, keys, charger, and water bottle. Voiceover: “First, essentials: the stuff you touch all day.”

0:11-0:18 - Second pile. On-screen text: “Zone 2: Comfort.” Show hoodie, snack, sunscreen pouch, hand wipes, and mini first-aid pouch. Voiceover: “Second, comfort: the small things that keep the day from getting annoying.”

0:19-0:27 - Third pile. On-screen text: “Zone 3: After-class plan.” Show headphones, book, compact picnic mat, and travel organizer. Voiceover: “Third, your after-class plan. Study outside, meet a friend, hit the park, or take a quick walk.”

0:28-0:36 - Pack items into HarborTrail Everyday Daypack. Show laptop sleeve, water bottle pocket, organizer, and clean final look. Voiceover: “The goal is not more stuff. It is fewer decisions.”

0:37-0:45 - Final shot walking across campus or out the door. On-screen text: “Save this + get the free checklist.” Voiceover: “Save this setup and grab the free Campus Bag Checklist from HarborTrail.” Include captions for accessibility.

LINK TO VIDEO: <https://youtube.com/shorts/00kHitpW8iY>

Platform Fit Explanation: Why does this platform fit the chosen audience and goal?

TikTok fits Campus Explorer Alex because the persona already uses TikTok and responds to fast, relatable, practical content. The platform rewards clear hooks, quick transformations, humor, and useful demonstrations. A campus bag reset is easier to understand visually than in text alone. TikTok also gives HarborTrail a way to fix the weak social traffic from Round 1 by turning the blog’s helpful advice into a shareable, saveable format.

Client Quality Check: 1) How does your video fit the audience? 2) How does it support the goal? 3) Why is the platform appropriate? 4) Is the CTA clear? 5) What would you improve with more time?

The video fits students because it solves a real daily problem: carrying school, commuting, food, and after-class items without chaos. It supports engagement through a strong hook, fast visual payoff, and a save-worthy checklist format. TikTok is appropriate because Alex uses the platform and the idea can be understood in less than a minute. The CTA is clear: save the video and tap the link for the checklist. With

more time, I would test two hooks, one humorous and one more practical, to see which earns more saves and shares.

Round 3: Podcast/Audio and Email Strategy

Client Memo

HarborTrail's short-form video helped increase visibility, but the brand now wants to build deeper trust. The next content piece should feel more personal, thoughtful, or story-driven. You will plan a short podcast, audio segment, or video podcast segment and connect it to an email newsletter strategy.

Round 2 Mock Analytics

Platform	Views	Engagement Rate	Clicks	Notes
TikTok	2,800	7.5%	38	Strong response from students and younger users
Instagram Reels	1,650	5.2%	29	Many saves and shares
YouTube Shorts	720	2.8%	8	Lower reach
Facebook	540	2.1%	14	Some family-oriented interest
Round budget		\$350		
Main focus		Trust-building audio/video-podcast concept plus email support		
Required artifact		2 to 3 minute script or detailed outline plus email newsletter plan		

Required Tasks

1. Interpret the Round 2 analytics.
2. Choose one target persona.
3. Choose one primary goal.
4. Plan a short podcast, audio segment, or video podcast segment.
5. Write a 2 to 3 minute script or detailed outline.
6. Plan one email newsletter that promotes the content.
7. Choose your content activities from the budget menu and stay within \$350.
8. Complete the Client Quality Check.

Possible Podcast/Audio Topics

- How to Make Weekend Adventures Feel Easier
- The Story Behind HarborTrail's Everyday Adventure Philosophy
- Three Small Gear Choices That Make a Big Difference
- How to Pack Less but Feel More Prepared
- Low-Waste Habits for Everyday Travel

Round 3 Response Template

Analytics Interpretation: In 100 to 150 words, explain what the video results suggest. Which audience or platform seems most promising? What should HarborTrail do next?

Round 2 shows that TikTok is the strongest platform for reach and engagement, with 2,800 views, a 7.5% engagement rate, and 38 clicks. Instagram Reels is also promising because it produced many saves and shares, which suggests the content has planning value beyond quick entertainment. YouTube Shorts and

Facebook underperformed for this specific video approach. HarborTrail should keep using short-form video for visibility, but the next step should build trust by giving the brand a more personal voice. A short audio or video podcast segment can deepen the “everyday adventure” philosophy, while email can convert interested viewers into a more owned audience.

Target Persona	Weekend Planner Maya
Primary Goal	Build trust and improve email engagement
Podcast/Audio/Video Podcast Title	Pack Less, Go More: Making Weekend Adventures Easier
Topic	How to make weekend adventures feel easier by reducing decision fatigue and packing smarter.
Main Message	Simple preparation lowers stress and makes local adventures feel more accessible.
Call to Action	Join the email list and download the Weekend Adventure Checklist.
Distribution Channel(s)	Website/blog embed, email newsletter, Instagram Story link, optional short clip on Instagram Reels
Budget Allocation	Podcast/audio segment: \$150; email newsletter: \$75; basic photo package: \$100. Total: \$325 of \$350.
Success Metric	Podcast listens, email open rate, email click rate, checklist downloads, and product clicks.

Podcast/Audio Script or Detailed Outline: Write a 2 to 3 minute script or detailed outline with a beginning, middle, ending, and call to action.

Beginning:

Welcome to HarborTrail Notes, a short series about making everyday adventure easier. Today’s topic is simple: how to pack less but feel more prepared. A lot of people want to do more on the weekend, but the plan gets heavy before it even starts. You think about the weather, snacks, chargers, where to sit, what bag to bring, and suddenly a simple day trip feels like work.

Middle:

The first shift is to stop packing for every possible situation and start packing for the most likely version of the day. Ask three questions: Where am I going? How long will I be out? What would make the day more comfortable? For most local adventures, that answer is not a giant suitcase. It is water, a charged phone, a layer, a snack, sunscreen, a small first-aid pouch, and one flexible bag.

The second shift is to use categories. Essentials keep you functioning. Comfort items keep small problems from becoming big ones. Activity items support the reason you are going out, whether that is reading, taking photos, having a picnic, or walking a trail. When these categories are organized, your bag becomes calmer. You know where things are, and you are less likely to bring duplicates.

The third shift is to leave space. A good weekend bag has breathing room. Maybe you buy coffee beans from a local shop, pick up a hoodie, or bring home something from a market. Leaving space makes the trip feel

flexible instead of overloaded.

Ending:

Everyday adventure does not require perfect conditions. It requires a small plan and gear that supports the day without taking over the day. If you want a simple starting point, download HarborTrail's Weekend Adventure Checklist. It will help you pack the basics, skip the clutter, and get out the door faster.

Email Subject Line	Pack less. Go more this weekend.
Email Preview Text	A simple checklist for easier local adventures, day trips, and weekend plans.
Opening Paragraph	Weekend plans should not feel like a logistics puzzle. This week, we are sharing a short HarborTrail Notes segment about packing less while still feeling prepared for a park visit, beach afternoon, coffee trip, or short hike.
Email Call to Action	Listen to the 3-minute segment and download the Weekend Adventure Checklist.
Why this email fits the audience	Maya likes planning guides, beautiful but practical weekend ideas, and simple systems that reduce friction. Email gives her something she can save, revisit, and use before the weekend.

Client Quality Check: 1) How does your podcast/audio idea fit the audience? 2) How does it build trust or support the goal? 3) Why is the email strategy appropriate? 4) Is the CTA clear? 5) What would you improve with more time?

The podcast/audio idea fits Weekend Planner Maya because it gives thoughtful planning advice without making adventure feel complicated. It builds trust by explaining the brand's everyday adventure philosophy in a human voice instead of only showing products. The email strategy is appropriate because Maya values checklists and planning support, and email creates a direct channel that is less dependent on platform algorithms. The CTA is clear: listen to the short segment and download the checklist. With more time, I would add a local creator voice to make the story feel even more community-based.

Round 4: Analytics and Budget Reallocation

Client Memo

HarborTrail has now tested blog, short-form video, podcast/audio, email, and Instagram carousel content. The owner wants to know where to focus next. Your job is to analyze the dashboard, make budget decisions, and plan the next set of content requests.

Campaign Dashboard

Content Type	Views/Opens	Engagement Rate	Clicks	Email Signups	Revenue Attributed
Blog post	730 views	3.8%	44	18	\$210
Short-form video	4,450 views	7.1%	67	21	\$330
Podcast/audio	310 listens/views	4.0%	11	6	\$75

Content Type	Views/Opens	Engagement Rate	Clicks	Email Signups	Revenue Attributed
Email newsletter	390 opens	6.4% click rate	25	N/A	\$260
Instagram carousel	1,200 views	5.9%	19	7	\$95

Audience Response

Audience	Strongest Content Type	Weakest Content Type	Notes
Campus Explorer Alex	Short-form video	Podcast/audio	Responds to practical, funny, fast content
Weekend Planner Maya	Blog + Instagram carousel	Podcast/audio	Saves planning guides and visual checklists
Family Outing Nora	Email + blog	TikTok	Likes clear checklists and reminders
Low-Waste Traveler Riley	Blog + educational carousel	Product-heavy posts	Responds to transparency and useful tips

Round budget	\$500
Main focus	Analytics interpretation and strategic reallocation
Required artifact	Strategy analysis plus three new content requests

Required Tasks

1. Analyze the campaign dashboard.
2. Identify the strongest content type and explain why.
3. Identify the weakest content type and explain why.
4. Choose one primary audience to prioritize next.
5. Create three new content requests.
6. Allocate the \$500 budget across your three content requests.
7. Explain what HarborTrail should stop, start, and continue doing.
8. Complete the Client Quality Check.

Round 4 Response Template

Strategy Analysis: In 300 to 500 words, explain what is working best, what is not working as well, which audience HarborTrail should prioritize next, which content types deserve more investment, and what the data suggests overall.

The campaign dashboard shows that HarborTrail's strongest overall content type is short-form video. It produced 4,450 views, the highest engagement rate at 7.1%, the most clicks at 67, the most email signups at 21, and the highest attributed revenue at \$330. That makes it the clearest awareness and engagement driver. The blog post also performed well, with 730 views, 44 clicks, 18 email signups, and \$210 in attributed revenue. This confirms that search-driven practical content matters, especially for audiences who plan ahead. The email newsletter is also strategically strong. Even though it had only 390 opens, it generated \$260 in attributed revenue, which suggests email is closer to conversion than awareness.

Podcast/audio is the weakest content type in this simulation. It had only 310 listens/views, 11 clicks, 6 email signups, and \$75 in revenue. That does not mean HarborTrail should never use audio, but it should reduce investment until the brand has a larger audience or a stronger storytelling reason. The data also shows that the weakest content type depends on audience. Students respond to short, funny, practical video, while Weekend Planner Maya saves blogs and carousels. Family Outing Nora responds to email and blog content, while Low-Waste Traveler Riley prefers educational and transparent content.

The best next priority is Weekend Planner Maya. She connects two of the better-performing content types:

blog and Instagram carousel. She also aligns with the Everyday Adventure concept because weekend planning, packing lists, short hikes, coffee stops, parks, and beaches are natural HarborTrail use cases. Maya can also move through the customer journey cleanly: discover a blog through search, save a carousel on Instagram, download a checklist, then click through to a daypack, organizer set, bottle, or tote.

HarborTrail should increase investment in short-form video, blog content, Instagram carousels, and email. These channels either create reach or support conversion. It should reduce standalone podcast/audio and avoid product-heavy posts that do not provide enough value first. The strongest strategic pattern is simple: lead with practical help, make it visual, capture email, then connect products to the specific use case.

Strongest Content Type and Why

Short-form video is strongest because it produced the most views, highest engagement rate, most clicks, most email signups, and highest revenue. It is the best top-of-funnel content type for awareness and quick action.

Weakest Content Type and Why

Podcast/audio is weakest because it produced the lowest reach, clicks, email signups, and revenue. It may build trust over time, but it is not the best use of limited budget right now.

Primary Audience to Prioritize Next and Why

Weekend Planner Maya should be prioritized because she responds to blog content and Instagram carousel content, both of which support planning, saves, search traffic, and product interest.

Budget Allocation: Explain how you will spend the \$500 round budget across the three content requests.

Instagram carousel: \$75; standard blog post: \$150; downloadable checklist/guide: \$200; email newsletter: \$75. Total: \$500.

Content Request #1: Include target persona, goal, search intent if relevant, content type, channel, title/hook, main message, CTA, budget used, and reasoning.

Target Persona: Weekend Planner Maya.

Goal: increase engagement and saves.

Search intent: informational/community engagement.

Content type: Instagram carousel. Channel: Instagram.

Title/hook: "5 Things to Pack for a No-Stress Day Trip."

Main message: a simple packing system makes spontaneous weekend plans easier.

CTA: "Save this for Friday and download the full checklist."

Budget used: \$75.

Reasoning: Maya saves visual planning guides, and carousel content performed well with her audience.

Content Request #2: Include target persona, goal, search intent if relevant, content type, channel, title/hook, main message, CTA, budget used, and reasoning.

Target Persona: Weekend Planner Maya.

Goal: increase website visits and product interest.

Search intent: informational/commercial investigation.

Content type: standard blog post.

Channel: blog/website and Pinterest.

Title/hook: "The Simple Weekend Adventure Packing Guide."

Main message: HarborTrail products support simple local travel without overpacking.

CTA: "Download the guide and explore the Travel Organizer Set."

Budget used: \$150.

Reasoning: Blog content performed well, and Maya uses search when planning weekend activities.

Content Request #3: Include target persona, goal, search intent if relevant, content type, channel, title/hook, main message, CTA, budget used, and reasoning.

Target Persona: Weekend Planner Maya with secondary value for Family Outing Nora.

Goal: increase email signups and repeat engagement.

Search intent: informational.

Content type: downloadable checklist/guide plus email newsletter.

Channel: website landing page and email.

Title/hook: "Everyday Adventure Checklist."

Main message: one practical checklist can support parks, beaches, short hikes, campus picnics, and family outings.

CTA: "Join the list to download the checklist."

Budget used: \$275 (\$200 guide + \$75 email).

Reasoning: This uses a strong lead magnet to convert search and social attention into an owned audience.

Stop / Start / Continue: What should HarborTrail stop doing or reduce? What should it start doing? What should it continue doing?

Stop or reduce standalone podcast/audio for now because the current data does not justify continued investment at the same level. Also reduce product-heavy posts that do not begin with useful advice. Start creating more downloadable checklists and guide-based email capture points because they connect practical value to product interest. Start repurposing blog topics into carousels and short videos so one idea can work across search and social. Continue short-form video, blog posts, Instagram carousels, and email because these content types show the strongest mix of awareness, engagement, clicks, signups, and revenue.

Client Quality Check: 1) Do your new requests follow the data? 2) Are they realistic for the budget? 3) Do they fit the audience? 4) Are the CTAs clear? 5) What risk or uncertainty remains?

The new requests follow the data because they prioritize blog, short-form visual planning content, Instagram carousel, and email capture rather than weak standalone audio. They are realistic for the \$500 budget and use the full round budget without overspending. They fit Weekend Planner Maya because they provide weekend guides, packing lists, visual checklists, and simple CTAs. The CTAs are clear: save, download, join the list, and explore relevant products. The remaining uncertainty is whether Maya's saves and checklist downloads will convert into purchases at a strong enough rate; that should be tracked in the next campaign.

Round 5: Final Integrated Strategy Memo

Client Memo

HarborTrail is preparing a two-week campaign called Everyday Adventure Challenge. The campaign invites people to plan one simple local adventure: a campus study picnic, neighborhood walk, short hike, park visit, beach afternoon, family outing, or low-waste day trip. The owner wants a complete content strategy that uses what you learned from the previous rounds.

Round budget	\$600
Campaign name	Everyday Adventure Challenge
Main focus	Integrated campaign strategy and final recommendation
Required artifact	Final content plan, strategy memo, and reflection

Required Tasks

1. Choose one primary target persona.
2. Choose one secondary target persona.
3. Define the campaign's main message.
4. Plan at least five content pieces across at least three channels.
5. Allocate the \$600 budget.
6. Explain how each content piece supports the customer journey.
7. Recommend success metrics.
8. Write a final strategy memo of approximately 800 to 1,200 words.
9. Write a final reflection of approximately 250 to 400 words.

Customer Journey Options

For each content piece, explain whether it is mainly designed for awareness, engagement, consideration, email sign up, product interest, purchase/conversion, or community building.

Round 5 Response Template

Primary Target Persona				Weekend Planner Maya			
Secondary Target Persona				Campus Explorer Alex			
Main Campaign Message				Adventure does not have to be extreme, expensive, or far away. Plan one simple local adventure with practical gear that makes the day easier.			
Content Piece	Target Audience	Goal	Channel	Content Type	Budget	CTA	Success Metric

1	Maya	Awareness	Blog + Pinterest	Short Blog	\$100	Read Guide	Views, Time
2	Maya	Engagement	Instagram	Carousel	\$75	Save / Share	Saves, Shares
3	Alex	Awareness	TikTok + Reels	Vertical Video	\$150	Post Setup	Views, Comments
4	Maya + Alex	Email Signup	Landing Page	Checklist	\$200	Download	Signups
5	Maya + Alex	Conversion	Email	Newsletter	\$75	Shop Kit	Clicks, Revenue

Budget Rationale: Explain how you spent the \$600 and why.

The \$600 budget is allocated toward content types that already showed stronger performance: blog/search content, short-form video, Instagram carousel, and email. The downloadable checklist receives the largest share because it turns attention into an owned audience and supports the campaign's two-week challenge. Short-form video receives \$150 because it was the strongest content type for reach, engagement, clicks, signups, and revenue. The blog and carousel support Maya's planning behavior, while the email newsletter supports conversion and repeat engagement. No money is assigned to standalone podcast/audio because the dashboard showed weaker performance and the campaign needs efficient movement through the customer journey.

Customer Journey Explanation: Explain how each content piece supports awareness, engagement, consideration, email signup, product interest, purchase/conversion, or community building.

The blog post supports awareness and consideration by helping Weekend Planner Maya discover simple local adventure ideas through search and Pinterest. The Instagram carousel supports engagement because it is easy to save, share, and revisit while planning. The short-form video supports awareness and community building by turning the campaign into a challenge that students and younger users can quickly understand. The downloadable checklist supports email signup because it gives the audience a practical reason to join HarborTrail's list. The newsletter supports product interest and conversion by connecting the challenge to a curated Everyday Adventure Kit with relevant products such as the Everyday Daypack, Insulated Water Bottle, Travel Organizer Set, Compact Picnic Mat, and Trail Comfort Kit.

Final Strategy Memo: Write approximately 800 to 1,200 words. Include executive summary, target audience rationale, content strategy, budget rationale, analytics-based reasoning, success metrics, and final recommendation.

Executive Summary

HarborTrail Outfitters should launch the two-week Everyday Adventure Challenge as a practical, inclusive campaign that invites people to plan one simple local adventure. The campaign should not position adventure as extreme, expensive, or only for expert hikers. Instead, it should show that adventure can be a campus study picnic, neighborhood walk, short hike, beach afternoon, park visit, family outing, or low-waste day trip. Based on the simulation data, the strongest campaign structure is a mix of search-driven content, short-form video, Instagram carousel content, a downloadable checklist, and email. This combination gives HarborTrail both reach and conversion: people can discover the brand, save useful content, join the email list, and click into relevant products.

Target Audience Rationale

The primary target persona should be Weekend Planner Maya. Maya is a young professional who wants easy weekend escapes, short hikes, local coffee shops, road trips, parks, beaches, and simple travel planning. She is the best strategic fit for this campaign because the data shows she responds well to blog content and Instagram carousels. She also uses Instagram, Pinterest, TikTok, blogs, and Google Search, which gives HarborTrail several realistic channels for reaching her. The secondary target persona should be Campus Explorer Alex. Alex responds to short, practical, funny content and uses TikTok, Instagram Reels, YouTube Shorts, and Reddit. Alex helps the campaign gain social visibility and gives the Everyday Adventure Challenge a younger, faster-moving social layer.

Content Strategy

The campaign's main message should be: adventure does not have to be extreme, expensive, or far away. Plan one simple local adventure with practical gear that makes the day easier. This message fits HarborTrail's friendly, inclusive, and practical brand voice. It also connects directly to the product line without making the content feel overly sales-driven.

The campaign should include five content pieces across at least three channels. First, HarborTrail should publish a short blog post titled "7 Simple Local Adventure Ideas for This Weekend." This post will support awareness and consideration by giving Maya easy ideas she can find through search or Pinterest. Second, HarborTrail should create an Instagram carousel titled "Pack This, Not That: Weekend Day Trip Edition." This piece supports engagement because it is visual, useful, and saveable. Third, HarborTrail should create a short-form vertical video called "One Bag Weekend Challenge." This video should invite Alex and Maya to show how they pack for one simple local adventure. Fourth, HarborTrail should create a downloadable Everyday Adventure Checklist. This is the lead magnet that converts interest into email signups. Fifth, HarborTrail should send an email newsletter that introduces the challenge, links to the checklist, and presents a simple Everyday Adventure Kit.

Budget Rationale

The \$600 budget should be allocated carefully: \$100 for a short blog post, \$75 for an Instagram carousel, \$150 for a short-form vertical video, \$200 for the downloadable checklist, and \$75 for the email newsletter. This budget follows the simulation evidence. Short-form video generated the highest reach, engagement, clicks, email signups, and revenue, so it deserves continued investment. Blog content generated meaningful search traffic, product clicks, and signups, so it should remain part of the plan. Instagram carousel content fits Maya's behavior because she saves planning guides and visual checklists. The downloadable checklist receives the largest budget share because it connects social and search content to email list growth. Email receives a smaller but important investment because it generated strong revenue compared with its number of opens.

Analytics-Based Reasoning

The campaign dashboard shows a clear pattern: practical, useful content performs better than content that is too passive or product-heavy. Short-form video was the strongest content type, with 4,450 views, a 7.1% engagement rate, 67 clicks, 21 email signups, and \$330 in revenue. Blog content also performed well with 730 views, 44 clicks, 18 signups, and \$210 in revenue. Email had fewer opens but strong revenue at \$260, which suggests it is valuable for conversion. Podcast/audio was the weakest content type, with only 310 listens/views, 11 clicks, 6 signups, and \$75 in revenue. For this reason, the campaign should not spend limited budget on standalone audio. HarborTrail can return to audio later when the brand has a larger audience or a more developed storytelling series.

Success Metrics

The campaign should track metrics across the full customer journey. Awareness should be measured

through blog views, video views, reach, and Pinterest clicks. Engagement should be measured through Instagram saves, shares, comments, TikTok engagement rate, and challenge participation. Email signup should be measured through checklist downloads and conversion rate on the landing page. Product interest should be measured through product clicks from the blog, checklist, and email. Purchase/conversion should be measured through attributed revenue from the Everyday Adventure Kit and individual product links. HarborTrail should also track which audience responds most strongly so the next campaign can be refined.

Final Recommendation

HarborTrail should move forward with the Everyday Adventure Challenge using a practical help-first strategy. The campaign should make local adventure feel simple, low-pressure, and affordable. The best creative direction is not “buy this gear so you can be adventurous.” The stronger message is “choose one simple plan, pack with intention, and make the day easier.” That approach gives HarborTrail credibility, supports the brand voice, and creates natural product relevance. The company should continue investing in short-form video for reach, blog/search content for discovery, Instagram carousel content for saves and planning behavior, and email for conversion. It should reduce standalone audio and avoid product-heavy posts unless they are attached to a useful guide, checklist, or challenge. This strategy gives HarborTrail a realistic two-week campaign that can build awareness, grow community, capture email signups, and encourage product clicks without losing the brand’s friendly everyday adventure identity.

Final Reflection: Write approximately 250 to 400 words. What did you learn? What was harder than expected? How did analytics influence your decisions? How did audience thinking change your content choices? What would you do differently with a real client?

This assignment helped me understand that content strategy is not just about making creative posts. It is about connecting the audience, goal, platform, message, budget, and metric into one working system. I am grateful to have learned this process because it gave me a clearer framework for how content can move from an idea into a strategic campaign. The harder part was not coming up with ideas; the harder part was deciding which ideas deserved budget based on the data. It is easy to like a creative idea because it sounds interesting, but the analytics forced me to ask whether that idea actually helped HarborTrail reach people, earn clicks, build email signups, or support product interest.

The analytics changed my decisions throughout the simulation. At first, search-driven blog content made sense because HarborTrail was not well known and needed discovery. I was surprised to see that hashtags were not really a part of any analytical thoughts. After Round 1, the weak social traffic showed that the same advice needed to become more visual and platform-native. After Round 2, TikTok and Instagram proved that short-form content could create stronger engagement. Later, the dashboard showed that podcast/audio was not performing as strongly as blog, video, carousel, and email. That influenced the final campaign because I reduced audio and focused on content types with stronger evidence.

Audience thinking also changed the content choices. Campus Explorer Alex needed fast, practical, relatable content. Weekend Planner Maya needed planning guides, checklists, and visual inspiration. Family Outing Nora needed reminders and clear family-friendly planning support. Low-Waste Traveler Riley needed transparency and useful education. Seeing these differences helped me understand that strong content strategy is not one-size-fits-all. Each audience needs a different doorway into the brand.

One of the biggest takeaways for me is that these simulations are not just classroom exercises. They are frameworks I can test in the real world. I plan to take myself, my personal brand, and my business through this same process to build up my own endeavors. By applying these steps to my own work, I can test content ideas, measure results, improve my strategy, and create proof of my own success. Once I can show that

these methods work for my own brand and business, I can eventually package and sell this knowledge as part of my business offerings.

With a real client, I would want to test more creative variations, collect actual comments and customer questions, and interview customers to understand what prevents them from taking simple local adventures, and experiment with hashtag strategy for discoverability. I would not treat hashtags as the main metric, but I would track whether certain hashtags, captions, and keyword phrases helped content reach the right audience. I would also build a content calendar that repurposes one strong idea into multiple formats instead of treating each post as separate work. This assignment helped me see content strategy as both a creative practice and a business system.

4. Final Requirements

AI Use Disclosure

You may use AI tools for brainstorming, outlining, editing, or generating ideas unless your instructor states otherwise. However, your final submission must reflect your own thinking and strategic judgment. You may not simply copy and paste AI-generated work and submit it as your own.

AI Use Disclosure: Write either 'I did not use AI for this assignment' or explain how you used AI and how you revised the work yourself.

I used AI for brainstorming, outlining, spellchecking, and revising my work. I also used AI to generate the video component from Round 2. I attempted to create a Podcast for Round 3 but it did not sound very good. I reviewed the assignment requirements, selected strategic directions, checked the budget constraints, and revised the final work so the recommendations fit HarborTrail's brand voice, personas, mock analytics, and campaign goals.

Citation and Source Expectations

If you use outside sources, cite them clearly. This includes statistics, platform data, images, articles, trend reports, or factual claims. You may use a simple citation format with organization/author, year if available, title/page name, and link if available. Formal APA formatting is not required unless your instructor states otherwise.

References, if applicable

Hootsuite Academy. (2022). Best practices for sharing Instagram [Infosheet]. In Hootsuite social media marketing certification course. Hootsuite Academy.

Hootsuite Academy. (2022). Best practices for sharing Pinterest [Infosheet]. In Hootsuite social media marketing certification course. Hootsuite Academy.

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Hootsuite Academy. (2022). Hootsuite social metrics [Infosheet]. In Hootsuite social media marketing certification course. Hootsuite Academy.

Privacy and Accessibility Expectations

- Do not include private information about yourself or others.
- You are not required to post publicly or show your face.
- If you create video/audio, include captions, a transcript, or a script when possible.
- Use clear headings and readable formatting.
- Use images, music, or clips only if you have permission or they are clearly free to use.

Final Portfolio Checklist

Item	Included?
Round 1 content request, blog post draft, strategy explanation, and Client Quality Check	Yes
Round 2 analytics interpretation, video plan, script/storyboard/production plan, caption/CTA, and Client Quality Check	Yes
Round 3 analytics interpretation, podcast/audio plan, email strategy, budget allocation, and Client Quality Check	Yes
Round 4 strategy analysis, three content requests, budget allocation, Stop/Start/Continue, and Client Quality Check	Yes
Round 5 final content plan, budget rationale, customer journey explanation, final strategy memo, and final reflection	Yes
AI use disclosure	Yes
References, if applicable	N/A

Grading Rubric

This assignment will be graded out of 100 points and converted to the appropriate Canvas point value.

Criteria	Points	What strong work shows
Audience/persona analysis	10	Clear understanding of audience needs, motivations, pain points, and platform habits
Content strategy and goal alignment	15	Content choices clearly connect to campaign goals and brand strategy
Search intent and SEO keyword logic	10	Keywords and search intent are chosen thoughtfully and used appropriately
Content creation quality	20	Blog, video, podcast/audio, email, and campaign content are clear, audience-centered, and professionally developed
Budget allocation and distribution decisions	10	Budget choices are realistic, justified, and connected to audience/channel fit
Analytics interpretation and strategic adjustment	15	Mock data is interpreted accurately and used to improve decisions

Criteria	Points	What strong work shows
Self-review, revision logic, and professional reflection	10	Client Quality Checks show honest evaluation, improvement thinking, and strategic awareness
Final strategy memo and reflection	10	Final memo is clear, persuasive, evidence-informed, and professionally organized
Total	100	

A-Level Work

- Clearly connects audience, goal, content type, channel, message, budget, and success metric.
- Makes thoughtful strategic decisions rather than random content choices.
- Uses analytics to revise and improve the campaign.
- Shows creativity while staying realistic and brand-consistent.
- Submits a complete, organized, professional portfolio.

Work That Needs Significant Improvement

- Incomplete sections or missing rounds.
- Content choices that ignore the target audience or brand voice.
- No meaningful use of the budget system.
- Little or no analytics interpretation.
- Generic, copied, or not meaningfully revised work.
- Failure to follow the portfolio structure.

Final reminder

Think like a content strategist: audience first, goal second, platform third, content fourth, metrics always. The best work is creative, practical, audience-centered, and evidence-informed.